PARTICIPANT HANDOUT | LESSON 13

2 Corinthians Part 1

Power in Weakness

BIG IDEA God displays Christ's power through weak, suffering servants who minister with integrity and reconciliation.

Series location: Lesson 13 of 24 | 2 Corinthians 1-7

Primary texts: 2 Corinthians 3:4-18; 4:7-18; 5:1-21; 6:14-7:1

Series question: What problem is Paul addressing, and how does the gospel answer it?

Follow the movement

PASSAGE	MOVEMENT
1:3-2:13	God comforts suffering servants and calls conflicted believers toward integrity, forgiveness, and restoration.
2:14-3:18	God makes servants competent for a new covenant in which the Spirit gives life and transforms hearts.
4:1-18	Christ's treasure is carried in fragile jars so the sustaining power is clearly God's.
5:1-6:13	Resurrection hope produces courage, accountability, new creation, and a ministry of reconciliation.
6:14-7:16	Reconciled believers pursue holy allegiance, godly sorrow, repentance, and openhearted relationships.

New covenant ministry

IMAGE	GOSPEL FULFILLMENT
Stone tablets	The Spirit writes God's will on human hearts.
The law exposes sin and condemns	The Spirit gives life and brings righteousness.
Moses reflects fading glory	The Spirit's ministry has surpassing and enduring glory.
A veil hides understanding	The veil is removed when a person turns to the Lord.
External command	Believers behold Christ and are transformed into his image.

'The letter kills' does not mean that the Old Testament or careful biblical reading is harmful. God's law is holy and glorious, but external command cannot cure a rebellious heart or create obedience. The Spirit gives the life and transformation the law requires.

BEFORE NEXT WEEK Read 2 Corinthians 8-13. Mark what Paul teaches about generosity, spiritual authority, boasting, weakness, and the sufficiency of Christ's grace.

Treasure in jars of clay

FRAGILE SERVANTS	GOD'S SUSTAINING POWER
Hard pressed	Not crushed
Perplexed	Not in despair
Persecuted	Not abandoned
Struck down	Not destroyed
The outer person wastes away	The inner person is renewed day by day

Weakness does not prove that God has abandoned his servants. Christ's death and resurrection shape ministry: fragile people carry the gospel so that Christ's life and God's extraordinary power become visible.

Hope, accountability, and reconciliation

With Christ after death Believers who die are away from the body and at home with the Lord.

Resurrection at Christ's return Our final hope is a permanent resurrection body in which mortality is swallowed up by life.

Accountable before Christ Grace removes condemnation, but our deeds, motives, and stewardship still matter.

Ambassadors of reconciliation Christ reconciles sinners to God and entrusts reconciled people with his appeal: Be reconciled to God.

Contact, influence, and unequal yoking

CATEGORY	DISCERNMENT
Contact and friendship	Necessary for neighborly love, work, and Christian witness.
Media and social media	Not automatically a yoke; consider what shapes desire, normalizes sin, or weakens obedience.
Binding partnership	Ask whether shared authority, identity, vows, or obligations require compromised allegiance.
Idolatrous participation	Refuse worship or conduct that gives another power the allegiance owed to God.

The Gospel Then and Now

THEN AND NOW	GOSPEL RESPONSE
Pressure then	Measure ministry by impressive credentials, visible strength, and freedom from suffering.
Temptation now	Confuse polish, platform, growth, charisma, or constant success with God's power.
Faithful ministry	The Spirit transforms hearts; Christ's life appears in fragile, holy, reconciling servants.

Discuss

1. What makes Christian ministry credible?
2. How does the image of treasure in jars of clay challenge Christian celebrity culture?
3. What does it mean for an ordinary believer to serve as Christ's ambassador?
4. How can we distinguish contact, unhealthy influence, a binding yoke, and idolatrous participation?

FOR FURTHER STUDY
Related: Exodus 34:29-35; Jeremiah 31:31-34; Ezekiel 36:26-27; Romans 8:1-17
ECO: Essential Tenets II.B, III.C, III.D | Class resources: scan QR.

